bhajan that a local group of women sang in our film and it occurred to me that this is a dominant quality connecting the stories. It's not only talking about the presence of compassion but also the need for compassion in these times of conflicts," shares Singh.

Veteran actor Naseeruddin Shah plays Rashid Ali, while 60-year-old Punjabi poet Jaswant Zafar makes his debut as an actor. On directing Shah, Singh notes, "On the second or third day of the shoot, he said, 'The best directors are the ones who have not directed me.' I became very much at ease after that. Then, I was just seeing him direct himself," he says.

THE FILM WEAVES IN STORIES BY AUTHOR AJEET COUR AND NARRATES PUNJAB'S HISTORY OF MIGRATIONS, CONFLICT AND SOCIETAL SHIFTS

While the film resonated strongly with international audiences at Locarno, Singh emphasises its emotional core remains deeply rooted in the subcontinent. "This is a film for India, and I am hopeful that it will reach out to the maximum Indians. We are working towards a theatrical release," he adds. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

accompany westerners on mountaineering expeditions. However, the call of the 'Chomolungma' (Mother Goddess of the Earth) grabs the young yak herder's imagination when he is knee-high. He grows up dreaming of climbing Everest. By the time Norgay joins the British expedition for scaling Everest led by army officer John Hunt (Willem Dafoe), he has become seasoned. Still, being a Bhotia is a matter of consternation among the Sherpas he must lead. Meanwhile, Hillary (Tom Hiddleston), being a Kiwi among Britishers, causes another angle of discrimination. Only natural that the two resilient men are drawn to each other.

Tenzing, shot in Nepal, is buoyed by earnest performances and realistic footage. Settling in Darjeeling, from where most Everest expeditions began, Norgay's story did not need to wait for an Australian filmmaker. Nonetheless, it's a perfectly adequate biopic. ■

—Devarsi Ghosh

Tenzing is streaming on Apple TV

MUSIC ▼

THE ART OF SELFISHNESS

IN HER UPCOMING ALBUM, *KHUDGARZI*, SHEHERAZAAD EXPLORES A WOMAN'S STRUGGLE TO RECONCILE PERSONAL FREEDOM WITH SOCIETAL EXPECTATIONS

Selfishness is often seen as a flaw, something we are taught to suppress rather than acknowledge. American-Indian composer and performer Sheherazaad, however, is revisiting the idea through her debut album, *Khudgarzi*. Drawing from her experiences and the expectations she grew up with, the 10-track record explores a woman's struggle: duty or autonomy, sacrifice or survival?

Raised in California in a second-generation immigrant household, Sheherazaad was exposed to many music traditions. "I grew up listening to Hindustani and Carnatic music due to my roots in both regions. Growing up in America, I felt a sense of solidarity with other brown kids through our connections to each other's languages and music. Persian and Arabic music

> The album brings together instruments from *South Asia and the Middle East, with field recordings* and multilingual lyrics

"My entire life, I have had an fairly antagonistic relationship with selfishness; more like a phobia. I grew up feeling the pressure of the 'model minority' stereotype, where we were expected to project excellence, remain uncomplicated and be grateful always," she admits.

The album brings together traditional instruments from South Asia and the Middle East with contemporary production, field recordings and felt deeply personal to me throughout my childhood."

Describing herself as "a little genre-anarchist", she questions the boundaries imposed on artists working across cultures. "In today's racist global music machinery, artists from non-western traditions or languages are at a disadvantage. The stakes are much higher in experimentation and risk-taking," she says. ■

—Deepa Natarajan Lobo

Khudgarzi *releases on Nov. 20*



ZAYIRA RAY